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From the editor-in-chief

Every country and society has its power centres which have a major impact on the lives of its citizens quite apart from elected parliaments. The White House, 10 Downing Street and the Elysée Palace are the three best known, while in India, it is the Prime Minister's Office or PMO. Like the others, the PMO is deliberately kept away from the public gaze and is accessible only to a privileged few. Indeed, a majority of Indians have no idea of the influence and power the PMO's occupants wield since only the prime minister stays in the spotlight while his chosen aides remain largely in the background. Today, the PMO has grown into an all-powerful entity that is the conduit between the prime minister, the various arms of the Government, ministries and state governments as well as global leaders and institutions.

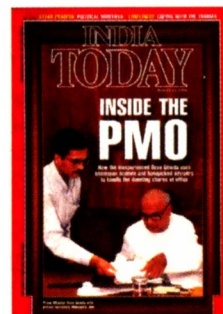
It wasn't always so. Back in 1984 when prime minister Indira Gandhi presided over India's destiny, the Prime Minister's Office consisted of two adjoining rooms in 1 Akbar Road, which, along with the adjacent bungalow, was her official residence-cum-office. The PMO then mainly consisted of trusted aide R.K. Dhawan, a few bureaucrats and security officials. Her focus was domestic politics and the PMO reflected that. Her son Rajiv took it to a new level of power and patronage when he surrounded himself with powerful bureaucrats and some Doon School friends—the late Gopi Arora, Mani Shankar Aiyar, Montek Singh Ahluwalia, G. Parthasarathy, Ronen Sen, Arun Singh and Pulok Chatterjee, to mention a few. After that, it declined in influence till A.B. Vajpayee's 1998-2004 tenure, when the PMO directed the economic reforms agenda and Brajesh Mishra was named Supercrat for his unprecedented clout.

Manmohan Singh is as low-key as any prime minister but his PMO has assumed vital importance and influence in terms of pushing agendas and policies. Because of the crucial role the PMO is currently exercising from 7 Race Course Road, we decided to take a close look at how it operates and profile the Prime Minister's Men, those who matter in the current dispensation. Like their boss, they prefer to keep a low profile but we were extremely fortunate that Senior Editor Saurabh Shukla was given access to all the key players in the PMO for candid on the record and off the record conversations and they also agreed to be photographed by INDIA TODAY photographers Hemant Chawla and Yashant Negi, including Principal Secretary TKA Nair during a recent key meeting with senior secretaries from strategically important ministries.

The unprecedented access convinced us that the prime minister has turned the PMO into an effective vehicle for governance without being heavy-handed or overbearing. Dissent is encouraged and dialogue is the norm and the academic in Manmohan seeks out divergent views before decisions are taken. His key aides are largely involved in his pet projects for inclusive growth and deciding the direction and emphasis of India's foreign policy, including more micro-management of our relations with our recalcitrant neighbours. Our cover story also looks at the handful of trusted politicians and bureaucrats like Ahluwalia who have direct access to the prime minister. On the whole, it is a rare, exclusive inside look at a powerful institution in the country and the people who run it.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)



OUR AUGUST
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